

Civil Society Organisational Strengthening Programme

Larika Network of Civil Society Organisations, Maikala

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Note: This excerpt covers Sections 3–5 of the full inception report (pages 8–17). Organisation names, individual names, and geographic identifiers have been retained as in the original submission. Budget and financial tables appear in Annex B (not included here).

3. Programme Context and Organisational Landscape

The Larika Network of Civil Society Organisations (hereinafter the Network) was established in 2009 as a membership-based coordinating body for civil society in Maikala, a small island state in the western Pacific. The Network currently counts 34 member organisations, of which 22 are classified as active (submitting annual returns and attending at least two Network convenings per year). The remaining 12 are dormant or inactive, a pattern the Network Secretariat attributes to post-pandemic funding attrition and the departure of key personnel from several member organisations between 2022 and 2024.

The Network's mandate covers three areas: coordination and information-sharing among civil society actors, policy advocacy at national level, and capacity strengthening of member organisations. In practice, the third function has received the least investment. The most recent capacity strengthening initiative predates the current leadership team, having been completed under a prior Sealight grant cycle in 2020–2021. Since then, no systematic organisational health assessment has been conducted across the membership.

Two member organisations — the Kopanu Solidarity Initiative (KSI) and the Marata Development Institute (MDI) — have been identified by the Sealight Foundation as directly funded civil society organisations (DFCSOs) with the strongest organisational infrastructure and delivery track record. KSI focuses on community legal empowerment and dispute resolution; MDI operates in the areas of women's economic inclusion and vocational training. Both organisations will receive targeted capacity strengthening support under this programme in addition to participating in the wider Network assessment process.

3.1 Governance Structure of the Network

The Network is governed by a Board of Directors comprising nine members elected by the membership at the Annual General Assembly. The current Board was elected in November 2023 for a two-year term expiring in November 2025. At the time of the inception visit (February 2026), no fresh elections had been held, and the Board was operating in a de facto extended mandate. This situation was raised by three member organisations during key informant interviews as a concern affecting the legitimacy of Board decisions, particularly with respect to a pending decision on the Network's next strategic plan.

The Board meets quarterly in person and on an ad hoc basis by video call. Attendance records provided by the Secretariat show an average quorum of 6.2 members per formal sitting over the last four meetings, which meets the constitutional minimum of five but reflects limited engagement from three Board members who have not attended any session in the past twelve months. The Board Chairperson, who has held the role since 2019, is widely respected for her sectoral knowledge but has indicated informally

that she does not intend to stand for re-election. The leadership succession question is considered a material risk to institutional continuity by both the Secretariat and the donor.

3.2 Staffing and Secretariat Capacity

The Network Secretariat employs seven full-time staff: an Executive Director, a Programme Manager, a Finance and Administration Officer, two Programme Officers, a Communications Officer, and a Driver. Three of these positions have been filled by new incumbents within the past fourteen months, including the Executive Director, who joined in December 2024 following the departure of the previous ED after seven years in post. Staff interviews conducted during the inception visit revealed a mixed picture: newer staff brought enthusiasm and in some cases stronger technical skills, but institutional knowledge — particularly regarding donor compliance obligations, member engagement protocols, and the Network's informal influence in national policy processes — was concentrated in two long-serving staff members.

- The Finance and Administration Officer has been with the organisation since 2014 and is considered the primary repository of financial compliance knowledge. Her absence during the inception visit (due to family bereavement) meant that several financial management questions could not be addressed during the field phase and have been deferred to the full assessment.
- The Programme Manager, also long-serving (since 2017), expressed concern during his interview that the new Executive Director's management style favours a more directive approach than the Network's culture has historically accommodated. He noted that two Programme Officers had raised concerns about task clarity and decision-making authority in a recent staff meeting.
- The Communications Officer, hired in March 2025, has a background in digital media rather than development communications. The Network's social media presence has improved markedly under her tenure, but her capacity to produce donor-facing technical reports remains untested.

4. Preliminary Organisational Health Findings

The assessment team administered the organisational capacity survey to 43 respondents across three categories: Network Secretariat staff (7), Board members (6 of 9 eligible), and representatives from member organisations (30, drawn from KSI, MDI, and 11 Network member organisations selected by purposive sampling). Responses are presented below across five organisational health domains. Domain scores represent the mean of all individual Likert item responses within the domain, expressed on a 1–5 scale where 1 indicates significant concern and 5 indicates strong organisational health. Scores below 3.0 are flagged for targeted intervention.

Domain	Staff (n=7)	Board (n=6)	Members (n=30)	Flag
Governance and Decision-Making	3.4	2.8	3.1	<i>Board score below threshold</i>
Financial Management and Accountability	3.7	3.2	2.6	<i>Member perception gap; further review needed</i>
Programme Design and Delivery	3.9	3.5	3.4	<i>Relatively strong across all groups</i>

Domain	Staff (n=7)	Board (n=6)	Members (n=30)	Flag
Human Resources and Organisational Culture	2.9	3.1	3.3	<i>Staff score below threshold; culture concerns noted</i>
External Relations and Resource Mobilisation	3.2	2.7	2.5	<i>Two scores below threshold; donor dependency a concern</i>

Table 1: Organisational health domain scores by respondent category. Scores below 3.0 are considered priority areas for intervention design.

4.1 Governance and Decision-Making

The governance domain presents a divergent picture across respondent groups. Secretariat staff rate governance at 3.4, reflecting reasonable confidence in day-to-day management clarity. Board members, however, score the domain at 2.8, below the intervention threshold, with particular concern concentrated in two sub-items: clarity of the Board's strategic oversight role versus management's operational authority, and confidence in the Board's ability to manage a leadership transition. Open-ended responses from Board members include references to 'role confusion between the ED and the Board Chair' and 'decisions being made informally before they reach the full Board.'

Member organisations score governance at 3.1, with variation between KSI (3.6, high confidence in Network governance), MDI (3.3), and the broader membership sample (2.9). Member concerns centre on the delayed election cycle and on perceptions that the Board is not adequately representing the interests of smaller, resource-constrained organisations in the Network. Two respondents noted that agenda items submitted by member organisations for the last Annual General Assembly were not incorporated into the final agenda without explanation.

4.2 Human Resources and Organisational Culture

The HR and culture domain returned the lowest staff score (2.9) of any domain, and the qualitative data from staff interviews provides substantial context for this finding. The transition from the previous Executive Director to the current one has introduced a period of adjustment that staff describe with varying degrees of difficulty. Three themes recurred across interviews:

- Task clarity and delegation: staff report uncertainty about who has authority to approve routine programme decisions, particularly in cases where the previous ED had established informal norms that are not reflected in the organisational chart or job descriptions.
- Performance management: no formal performance appraisal process has been conducted in the past 18 months. Two staff members indicated they were unsure of their performance standing relative to their supervisor's expectations.
- Psychological safety: while no staff member used this term, four of seven staff interviews included references to reluctance to raise concerns with the new ED directly, preferring instead to route feedback through the long-serving Programme Manager. This informal channel may be functioning as a pressure valve, but it is not a substitute for structured feedback mechanisms.

Board members and member organisation representatives score this domain higher (3.1 and 3.3 respectively), suggesting that the culture concerns are largely internal to the Secretariat and not yet visible at the Network level. This may reflect the short tenure of the new ED and a natural adjustment

period, or it may indicate that the issues are being managed without external visibility. The assessment team recommends that this domain receive focused attention in the full diagnostic phase.

4.3 External Relations and Resource Mobilisation

This domain returned the most consistently low scores across all respondent groups (staff 3.2, Board 2.7, members 2.5). The concerns are structural rather than operational. The Network currently derives approximately 74% of its income from a single donor, the Seelight Foundation, under the current programme. A second donor, which had supported the Network from 2018 to 2023, discontinued its funding following a strategic portfolio review. No replacement funder has been secured, and the Network's resource mobilisation strategy — last updated in 2021 — does not reflect the current funding landscape for Pacific civil society organisations.

Board members flagged the donor dependency issue more acutely than other groups, with three Board members explicitly noting concern about organisational viability beyond the current Seelight grant cycle (ending December 2027). Member organisations scored external relations lowest of all groups (2.5), reflecting a perception that the Network is not actively leveraging its convening role to surface member organisations to new funding opportunities — a function that several respondents identified as among the most valuable things the Network could offer.

5. Key Risks and Assessment Team Observations

The following risks are presented for donor and Network leadership attention. They are drawn from triangulated evidence across survey data, key informant interviews, document review, and direct observation during the inception visit. Risk ratings are indicative and will be reviewed at the midpoint of the full diagnostic phase.

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Assessment Team Observation
Leadership succession gap	High	High	<i>Board Chair has signalled she will not seek re-election; elections are overdue. No succession planning process is in place at Board or Secretariat level. Immediate facilitation of an elections roadmap is recommended.</i>
Institutional knowledge concentration	Medium	High	<i>Critical financial compliance and member relations knowledge is held by two long-serving staff. No knowledge transfer or documentation process exists. Risk is acute given the pace of recent staff turnover.</i>
Donor dependency and funding cliff	High	High	<i>74% income concentration in a single donor with a grant cycle ending December 2027. Resource mobilisation strategy is outdated. No active pipeline of prospective funders was identified during the inception visit.</i>
Secretariat culture transition	Medium	Medium	<i>Staff concerns about clarity, authority, and psychological safety are present but not yet affecting programme delivery. Early intervention through structured team dialogue and performance management reinstatement is advised.</i>

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Assessment Team Observation
Member organisation dormancy	Low	Medium	<i>12 of 34 member organisations are inactive. If further attrition occurs, the Network's legitimacy as a representative body may be questioned by the government and donors. A member re-engagement strategy should be incorporated into the capacity strengthening workplan.</i>

The assessment team notes that the risks identified above are not unusual for a Network organisation of this size and age at a moment of leadership transition. The Larika Network has demonstrated resilience through prior transitions and retains genuine convening authority and sectoral credibility within Maikala's civil society landscape. The programme design — which positions organisational strengthening as a sustained 18-month engagement rather than a discrete training intervention — is well-suited to the depth of change required. The assessment team's recommendation is to proceed to the full diagnostic phase with the risk register above informing the prioritisation of intervention areas.

End of excerpt (Sections 3–5). Sections 1–2 (Executive Summary and Methodology) and Sections 6–8 (Intervention Design, Workplan, and Annexes) are available in the full report.